Google Pixel Watch 5

Different and smart, with a Gemini coach on your wrist

When I got the Google Pixel 5, I was already reviewing a different watch, so I gave it to my wife. She has been wearing it for a month or so, and during this time, she accompanied me on a trip to Kerala. She donned it with different dresses during the trip and after. And this 41mm timepiece was her closest companion (pun intended) for most of the journey. Once the trip was over, I suggested that she use the new Google Health Coach feature to track her workouts at the gym, sleep and everyday health. And here you get a collaborative review, if you will, that covers the full experience of using that domed glass display, Pixel Watch UI features, and how useful the Gemini-based health advisor is. And by the end, you'll know if it is worth paying Rs 42,990 for this Google watch.

₹42,990

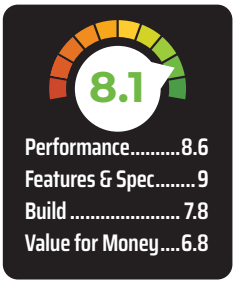


DESIGN

The Pixel Watch 5 comes in 41mm and 45mm sizes. Both are 12.3mm thick. Ours is the 41mm variant that weighs 31g without the strap. That's too light, and along with the smooth Active Band 2, it's comfortable to wear for long. This is important as the core of Google Health and fitness tracking relies on you wearing it through the day.

The watch is rated IP68 for dust and water resistance and 5 ATM for water resistance, so rain and surface swimming are within its intended use. The Active Band works for sweaty workouts.

The rounded pebble-like case with a curved display and the rubbery strap looks cute. Despite the Gorilla Glass 5 build, I am concerned about the long-term durability of the exposed edges. The whole design has a very 'Googley' character. My wife adores this look, while I don't mind the whole playful vibe. It is just that I can't accessorise it with anything I wear. Still, I appreciate that it is distinct and simple.



The strapping mechanism shares that distinct yet simple design language. There are enough holes on the strap to adjust it till you get a snug fit. The bands can be attached and detached using a sliding mechanism. While I would've preferred a conventional pogo-pin-based strap, I don't mind this bundled strap finish, and if you want more options, you can shop on the Google Store.

DISPLAY AND SOFTWARE

The 1.2-inch coloured AMOLED LTPO screen is plenty bright, smooth, and responsive. It can go up to a 60Hz refresh rate and drop to 1 nit for the AoD mode. Text elements were legible indoors and out under the sun.

The combination of the above panel, Wear OS 7 (with Pixel Watch UI), Qualcomm's Snapdragon W5 Gen 2 Accelerated processor, and 64GB of eMMC storage resulted in a lag-free experience.

You can customise the watch's fascia with the default watch faces or download/purchase ones you like from the Play Store. One gripe I have about the built-in watch faces is that they have a lot of black space. The software bezel is also thick, so the display could appear smaller, especially compared to the UI and watch faces you get on the Galaxy and Apple watches.

That said, Google has armed the Pixel Watch UI with a lot of ease-of-use features and functionalities. This includes Gemini, which can work without the internet to trigger alarms, timers, open apps, change settings and control workouts. Music Controls can automatically appear on the watch. Calls can be answered on the watch. Notifications can be answered with quick replies, and the company's apps like Google Maps are practical additions to the daily experience.

With the above features and the fact that the Pixel Watch can operate independently with LTE, you don't need to carry the phone along. While in Kerala, my wife used to wear the watch while going to the beach or poolside near our hotel room. Talk about convenience!

Google has also added some gestures, which you can toggle on/off from the Settings or Pixel Watch app. When they work, they are interesting. The double pinch to control music playback or notifications didn't work as intended in my test, and I didn't use it much.

AI COACH AND TRACKING

Google Health is now the centre of the experience if you are into health tracking. The app has four tabs: Today, Fitness, Sleep and Health. You can guess what each holds, but the amount of information and metrics is a lot. That